pilgrimage centres began to attract the faithful from the Chinese periphery.

China has the four sacred mountains associated with the Buddhist faith, its own ‘char dhams’. These are Mount Emei in Sichuan, Mount Putuo in Zhejiang, Mount Jiuhua in Anhui and Wutaishan in Shanxi. There are reports that sacred centres like Wutaishan dedicated to Manjusri, the Bodhisattva of Supreme Wisdom, even attracted pilgrims from India itself. Buddhism became another instrument for asserting the traditional Chinese notion of its centrality within the hierarchically ordered constellation of countries ranged along its periphery and beyond.

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The Sinicization of Buddhism was reflected in the development and spread of distinctively Chinese schools of Buddhist teachings, such as the Tiantai (Celestial Platform), the Huayan (Flower Garland), the Qing tu (Pure Land) and the Chan, better known as Zen, its Japanese version. Each of these doctrines took a particular Buddhist scripture as its foundation and each posited a long line of ‘transmission’ of the doctrine through a succession of patriarchs or teachers – something akin to the Indian ‘*guru–shishya parampara* ’ (master–pupil tradition), but much more institutionalized. In order to seek legitimacy, the original patriarchs in the genealogies were often listed as Indian masters, sometimes as the Buddha himself. Tiantai reveres the Lotus Sutra (Saddharma Pundarika Sutra) as constituting the highest teaching of the Buddha. In Japan, this became the Tendai school.

The Pure Land doctrine is the basis for the devotional cult of Buddha Amitabha who dwells in his ‘Western Paradise’ of Sukhavati. The chanting of the name of Amitabha (A-mi-to-fu in Chinese) ensures entry into Sukhavati, where there is neither pain nor sorrow. The foundational texts for the Pure Land doctrine are the Amitayus-Vipasyana-Sutra (Discourse Concerning Meditation on Amitayus) and the Sukhavati-Yyuha-Sutra (Description of the Western Paradise). Japan, too, had its version of the Pure Land doctrine, which was developed and systematized by the priest Honen.

The Huayan school draws inspiration from the Madhyamika (or Middle Way) teachings of Nagarjuna, the great Indian philosopher of Buddhism